

Peers-Observing-Peers

Structured peer observation to reveal real behaviour

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Peers-Observing-Peers is a research method in which members of a target community observe and document each other's behaviour, capturing candid, in-context actions that outsiders or self-reports would miss. It leverages insider access and trust.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

A participatory-research method embedded in design toolkits such as the HPI/Stanford-derived *Design Thinking Toolbox*.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

People behave differently when watched by outsiders and misreport their own habits. Peer observation reduces observer effects and reaches settings researchers cannot access.

HOW IT IS USED

Recruit and brief community members, give them a light observation guide, collect their notes and artefacts, then synthesise with the design team.

WHEN IT IS USED

Empathy phase, especially for private, sensitive or hard-to-access contexts.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Design researchers and teams doing community-based or participatory research.

FIGURE 1 · INSIDERS DOCUMENT INSIDERS



Figure 1. Members of the community observe and document one another, then hand candid evidence to the design team.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It extends observation into spaces researchers **cannot ethically or practically enter**, complementing AEIOU and empathy interviews.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

AEIOU *Slibrary 5*

Empathy Map *Slibrary 5*

Persona / User Profile *Slibrary 5*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Lewrick, M., Link, P. and Leifer, L. (2020) *The Design Thinking Toolbox*. Hoboken, NJ: Wiley.

IDEO (2015) *The Field Guide to Human-Centered Design*. San Francisco: IDEO.org.